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Too picky to be picked? Minimum mate standards explain number of years spent single, in uncommitted and committed relationships☆

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ABSTRACT

Humans seek to spend considerable portions of their lives in long-term mating relationships, yet remain selective about whom they are willing to partner with. We examined whether pickiness (i.e., minimum mate standards) predicts how many years individuals have spent single, in uncommitted relationships, and in committed relationships—expecting greater pickiness to result in more years spent single and in uncommitted relationships, and fewer in committed relationships. A representative Norwegian sample (N = 1182; ages 18–60) indicated their pickiness by rating minimum acceptable levels for 18 partner traits (e.g., intelligence, maturity, bodily attractiveness). They also reported the total time they had spent in committed and uncommitted relationships. The effects of pickiness were mixed. Among men, pickiness for physical attractiveness was associated with more years single, whereas overall pickiness unexpectedly was associated with fewer years single. Among women, overall pickiness was associated with more years in uncommitted relationships, but not with more years single. We use these findings to discuss whether singles' partner requirements are realistic, and whether they may contribute to rising rates of singlehood.

1. Introduction

Humans may be inferred to have some general drive to spend the majority of their lifespan in long-term mating relationships, owing to the compounding proximate and ultimate benefits long-term partnership-sprovide. At the ultimate level, time spent in long-term partnerships is the strongest relationship predictor of reproductive success (e.g., Andersson et al., 2023; Mulder & Ross, 2019)—including number of children and grandchildren (Međedović, 2022)—and is also associated with reduced mortality (Holt-Lunstad et al., 2010). At the proximate level, long-term partnerships confer purpose in life (Umberson et al., 2013), a sense of belonging (Baumeister & Leary, 1995), improved mental health (Grundström et al., 2021), and higher earnings (Pilossoph & Wee, 2021). The benefits of being partnered also appear independent of age (Grundström et al., 2021), as well as declining upon relationship dissolution and returning upon re-partnering (Luciano & Orth, 2017). Thus, the benefits of partnering appear to hold across the lifespan, suggesting that humans may have some general drive to maximize the proportion of their life spent partnered—a motivation that individuals themselves recognize, with a majority reporting near-maximum agreement with statements such as "I would like to have a romantic relationship that lasts forever" and "I hope to have a romantic relationship that lasts the rest of my life" (Jackson & Kirkpatrick, 2007).

However, it is not merely being in a relationship that matters, but also with whom. Humans are *picky*. They want the best partner they can get—or at the very least, someone who meets their minimum standards (Miller & Todd, 1998). There is a tension between the desire to be in a relationship and the desire to only be with a mate of certain fitness. Finding a partner that exceeds one's standards takes time. Time spent searching for a partner takes time away from being with a partner. And the higher one's standards, the longer it necessarily takes to find such a partner. Individuals therefore confront the challenge of determining how high to set their standards against the time it will cost them to find another who meets them.

Humans possess adaptations for adjusting their mate standards (Conroy-Beam & Buss, 2016). These adaptations help ensure that mate criteria remain realistic, preventing prolonged singlehood in pursuit of unattainable partners. However, since mating has been affected by societal and technological developments so rapidly that they outpace even a single generational turnover, adaptations responsible for setting

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realistic partner requirements may be susceptible to environmental mismatch. Accordingly, many singles report remaining unpartnered because they are "too picky" (Apostolou et al., 2020), even well into their 30s—"still waiting for [their] ideal" (Czernecka, 2011), as cited in (Adamczyk, 2023) Heterosexual women also appear to remain unpartnered due to continued involvement in uncommitted relationships with desirable men who do not want to commit (Larsen & Kennair, 2025). These observations suggest that singles may hold unrealistic mate standards, which prolong their singlehood.

Using a representative Norwegian sample aged 18–60, this study examined whether pickiness[1] increases the number of years individuals spend single and in uncommitted relationships, and decreases the years spent in committed relationships. We also address whether partner requirements are unrealistic by examining whether our sample's requirements exceed the trait levels the population can be expected to supply.

1.1. Adjusting mate standards

Human selectivity is adaptive given that the fitness benefits of being partnered scale with a partner's mate value. Individuals are therefore driven to set high standards for whom they are willing to partner with. Yet those standards must reflect the mate value of individuals available in one's mating pool and one's own mate value. Standards set above either threshold risk leaving individuals unpartnered. Humans are thus expected to possess adaptations that rapidly calibrate standards to realistic levels, hence minimizing time lost to unrealistic partner pursuit:

> This psychology [adaptation] also must take care to balance two competing demands: maximizing the mate value of the robot's ultimately chosen partner while also minimizing search costs en route to this choice… time and energy available for mate search is finite and resources spent doggedly pursuing unrealistic options could more profitably be spent pursuing partners more likely to be mutually interested… Selection is likely to have historically favored the evolution of [such] mate choice algorithms… (Conroy-Beam, 2023, p. 169–170).

The speed of these adaptations is also emphasized by Todd and Miller (1999), who, drawing on the secretary problem, showed in simulations that agents only require 12 encounters to identify standards reflective of individuals in their mating pool. Todd et al. (2005) further demonstrated that agents calibrate their standards to their own desirability with minimal time upon entering courtship. Most calibrated their standards to their own mate value and hence were reciprocally chosen into long-term partnership by around age 18, or as early as age 16 when models included an adolescent phase. In sum, adaptations are expected to require minimal time to identify realistically attainable mate standards, thereby reducing time spent unpartnered.

The historical marriage patterns these simulations were able to replicate also suggest that, until recently, adaptations governing mate-standard adjustment functioned effectively. In Norway, average age of first marriage was in the early 20s, with 90–95% becoming married before late adulthood (Statistics Norway, 2025). Over recent decades, however, a range of statistics indicate substantial declines in long-term mating worldwide (Stavang, 2026). In Norway, age of first marriage has risen to the mid-to-late thirties by 2024, with more than half of the population still never-married by age 50 (Statistics Norway, 2025). Registry data further estimate that the proportion of single Norwegian men aged 18–29 has grown from roughly 1 in 5 in 1980 to about half by 2021 (Bergløff et al., 2021). Increases in singlehood need not reflect excessive partner standards; numerous socio-cultural factors have been proposed, including rising individualism, higher educational attainment, women's emancipation, and shifting marital norms (e.g., Kislev, 2019; see Adamczyk, 2023, for a review). However, at the individual level, observations suggest that singles' mate standards may also be an important contributor to rising singlehood and to individuals spending more of their lives unpartnered.

Consider the following statement: "I'm single because I'm still waiting for my ideal." This statement was given by a woman in her 30s in (Czernecka, 2011), as cited in (Adamczyk, 2023) interviews with singles about their reasons for remaining unpartnered. It represented a category of singles who remained single because they were waiting for a "great love." This group consisted mostly of women in their 30s who either had not found a partner meeting their standards or had ended relationships with partners who had failed to meet their standards. A similar category of singles was identified by Adamczyk (2023), labeled *haven't met the right person*. In her qualitative study, this was the largest category, representing 44% of singles. It was illustrated by statements such as: "I have some specific patterns and I demand something both from myself and from someone else, so I think I just haven't found such a person yet, where there would be interest on both sides plus common needs and goals that we would pursue." (Adamczyk, 2023, p. 53). Quantitative surveys also point to singles' mate standards being excessive and contributing to them remaining single. Averaging across European, Asian, and South American cultures—Apostolou et al. (2021) found that 59% of singles expressed at least moderate agreement with statements reflecting difficulty in finding the right partner (e.g., "I cannot find someone interesting," "I am very picky"). Singles' own accounts thus suggest that excessive mate standards contribute, at least in part, to individuals spending less of their lives long-term partnered.

That individuals remain single in pursuit of high standards well past reproductive decline calls into question the current effectiveness of adaptations responsible for adjusting mate standards. As noted, these adaptations should be highly sensitive to the costs of "doggedly pursuing unrealistic options" (Conroy-Beam, 2023), and should therefore require minimal time to calibrate standards to be realistic (Todd et al., 2005; Todd & Miller, 1999). Because domains pertaining to mating have changed rapidly within a short timespan (Goetz, 2023), inefficacies in adaptations regulating pickiness may reflect adaptive lag. That is, when the environment evolves more rapidly than organisms can adjust through natural selection, adaptations become susceptible to environmental mismatch—resulting in reduced efficacy at solving their designated fitness tasks. By framing existing research through Li et al.' (2018) mismatch terminology (*input intensity, missing input, novel and fake cues*), an argument can be made that adaptations regulating pickiness may be among those experiencing mismatch. In the environment of evolutionary adaptedness, human societies likely numbered at most 300 individuals (Goetz et al., 2019). By contrast, today's metropolitan living and digital connectivity expose singles to an unprecedented number of potential partners. There is evidence that such increases in input intensity may bias the adaptations responsible for adjusting pickiness. For example, as the number of potential partners rises, satisfaction with each falls, prompting more rejection and greater chances of being rejected oneself (Pronk & Denissen, 2020). Moreover, frequent exposure to highly attractive individuals whose desirability is unrepresentative of one's actual mating pool may serve as novel or fake cues that bias the adjustment of mate expectations. Consistent with this, studies show that initial exposure to highly attractive potential partners leads individuals to evaluate subsequent prospects as less attractive than they otherwise would have (Kenrick & Gutierres, 1980; Lei et al., 2020). This initial exposure shapes mate choice behavior, making individuals less willing to accept partners who are less attractive than the more desirable option first encountered (Bhargava & Fisman, 2014). Furthermore, as mating has become increasingly autonomous (Apostolou, 2015; Goetz, 2023), individuals may experience missing input—particularly regarding which partners they can realistically attain. In arranged marriages,

[1] We use the terms pickiness and mate standards interchangeably. The colloquial term pickiness is included because readers from other disciplines may be less familiar with the technical term mate standards.

parents and kin typically selected partners of comparable social standing, thereby implicitly guiding offspring toward mates that reflected their own mate value. When mate choice is autonomous, individuals may lack necessary feedback for calibrating their expectations. Consistent with this, studies show that people tend to overestimate their mate value (Greitemeyer, 2020), and predominantly pursue partners who are more desirable than themselves—even though such pursuits are seldom successful (Bruch & Newman, 2018).

Several research findings indicate that individuals are struggling to realistically adjust their pickiness. To date, however, no studies have examined whether mate standards are associated with prolonged singlehood—a gap the present investigation aims to address.

1.2. Pickiness and uncommitted relationships

Unrealistic mate standards may affect not only the proportion of life spent single versus partnered, but also the time spent in uncommitted relationships. In Norway, as in other contexts where mate choice is autonomous and mutual, individuals primarily transition from singlehood to couplehood through courtship—often described in everyday terms as "dating." One of the functions of courtship is to assess whether a potential partner meets one's mate standards (Simão & Todd, 2002; Todd et al., 2005). Courtship is also the stage at which adaptations are expected to exert their strongest influence on mate-standard adjustment. Individuals are expected to calibrate their pickiness based on the acceptance and rejection they receive during courtship. Simulations have demonstrated that individuals rapidly calibrate their standards to align with their own desirability, allowing them to court realistically attainable partners and to transition out of courtship into long-term partnership (Todd et al., 2005). Real-world evidence supports this dynamic, with individuals recalibrating both their self-perceived mate value and their standards in response to dating feedback (Charlot et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2015). That individuals rapidly calibrate their standards during courtship to transition into long-term partnership is unsurprising, given that long-term mating is more strongly related to reproductive success than short-term mating, operationalized as number of sexual partners (Međedović, 2022).

Yet some singles appear "stuck" in courtship, cycling through dating or uncommitted sexual relationships without progressing to long-term partnership (Larsen & Kennair, 2025). Goetz et al. (2019) argue that because mate choice has become relatively free from parental input, individuals may feel less pressure to commit, leading to mate choice indecisiveness. Potentially, heightened mate standards may prolong involvement in uncommitted relationships, in case individuals are postponing commitment as they may wait to see if they encounter more desirable partners. Greater mate standards may therefore be expected to predict more years in uncommitted relationships.

It has also been argued that women's mate standards are particularly likely to affect their involvement in uncommitted sexual relationships (Larsen & Kennair, 2025). Since men have lower standards for short-term mating relationships than long-term partners (Buss & Schmitt, 1993; Kenrick et al., 1990; Kenrick et al., 1993), men are inclined to accept women as short-term sexual partners they nonetheless would reject as long-term partners. Consequently, women ought to differentiate between the men they can acquire for long-term relationships as opposed to only short-term sexual relationships. Larsen and Kennair (2025) have however argued that women tend to not lower their requirements for long-term partners relative to those they could set for short-term partners (primarily for physical appearance)—subsequently leading to women's increased involvement in uncommitted sexual relationships.

Excessive pickiness may therefore be expected to increase involvement in uncommitted relationships, particularly among women. To date, however, no studies have examined whether mate standards predict such involvement. The present study therefore also examines how mate standards relate to time spent in uncommitted relationships.

1.3. Current study

Recent rises in singlehood, and the apparent lengthening of time spent single, have in part been attributed to singles holding unrealistic mate standards. The aim of this study is to examine whether Norwegians' mate standards are excessive, and whether such standards predict prolonged singlehood.

Whether a given individual's standards are excessive depends on how those standards relate to their own mate value. Heuristically, standards aligned with one's mate value are calibrated, whereas standards exceeding it are miscalibrated. Because self-perceived mate value has been shown to lack construct validity in predicting objective mate value (Csajbók et al., 2019), the present study's survey methodology is unsuited to assess whether mate standards are miscalibrated at the level of the individual. Yet, whether mate standards are realistic may be assessed at the level of the population by drawing on principles of assortative mating. Traits considered mate preferences vary across individuals and therefore exhibit a characteristic distribution in the population—often approximately normal. Intelligence, for instance, is consistently identified as a desired trait in a partner (Walter et al., 2020) and is ca normally distributed in the population (Neisser et al., 1996). Under competitive assortative mating, individuals are expected to pair with—and therefore set their standards toward—others at roughly their equal level in the trait distribution (Schwartz, 2013). If mate standards in a population are realistically calibrated, individuals' minimum requirements for a given trait should be expected to generally align or overlap with the expected distribution of the trait in the population. Considerable deviation between standards and the trait distribution indicates that mate standards are excessive relative to what the population can supply. For example, if most people require their partner to be above average in intelligence, people's criteria for intelligence may be considered excessive. The first objective of this investigation is therefore to make an attempt at assessing whether mate standards are realistic at the level of the population, by examining whether a representative sample's mate standards align with the trait levels the population can be expected to supply.

- Research question 1: At the population level, is pickiness realistic or excessive?

Research suggests that pickiness is a reason for individuals currently being single, which also implies that pickiness results in individuals remaining single for longer. However, current research has not examined whether pickiness relates to actual increases in duration of singlehood. The present study therefore examines how pickiness co-varies with the total number of years spent single, as reported by a sample spanning a broad age range (18–60).

We also examine how pickiness predicts the number of committed and uncommitted relationships, as well as sexual partners. Since it is not given that extensive involvement in uncommitted relationships reflects pursuit of unattainable partners—and could potentially reflect individual's own short-term sexual strategy—we also examine whether pickiness predicts involvement in uncommitted relationships participants wished had progressed to commitment, and participants' beliefs of being single due to pursuing individuals unwilling to commit. We consider involvement in uncommitted relationships—where one's partner does not want to commit—as a proxy for pursuing partners above one's own mate-value. In sum, we examine the effects pickiness has on objective (e.g., years single) and subjective (e.g., interested in persons unwilling to commit) relationship involvement.

- Research question 2: Does pickiness predict relationship involvement?

When evaluating potential partners, individuals are expected to assess how closely a partner aligns with their overall mate standards (Conroy-Beam, 2023). Pickiness may therefore be miscalibrated at the overall level, as in expecting someone who "has it all." Mate standards

also comprise domains, including status, warmth, and physical attractiveness (Fletcher et al., 1999). Although we generally expect greater pickiness to predict fewer years in committed relationships, different domains may differentially affect relationship involvement. To model the effects of overall and domain-specific pickiness we attempt to model mate preferences using a bifactor model. In a bifactor model, measured mate standards originate from two sources: a global factor and a set of domain factors. There is also a research need to assess whether mate preferences fit a bifactor structure, as the co-variance between mate-preference domains is currently unexplained. Mate-preference factors typically correlate between 0.3 and 0.7 (e.g., Conroy-Beam et al., 2022, Supplementary Materials), indicating that they may share a common cause. Csajbók and Berkics (2017) attempted to capture these correlations using a higher-order factor, but the model did not fit the data well. A bifactor model may more effectively account for the correlations between mate preferences since it is less restrictive than a higher-order model.

- Research question 3: Can mate preferences be modeled using a bifactor model?

See Table 1 for an overview of research questions and variables being tested.

2. Method

2.1. Participants and Procedure

Participants were recruited through the survey agency Norstat, which employs a multi-step sampling procedure to ensure demographic representativeness of the Norwegian population (e.g., age, gender, geographic location). A total of 1182 respondents completed the survey (online, December 2023), first reporting their minimum partner preferences, then detailing the time they had spent in each relationship status. We excluded 25 participants who did not report their years in committed relationships, as we could not calculate their number of years as single. Nine participants who did not report their gender or their sexual-orientation were removed. The dataset was screened for multivariate outliers (e.g., Mahalanobis and Cook's distance) and highly unlikely scores (e.g., reporting longer relationship than age lived), resulting in the removal of twelve individuals. Using full-information maximum likelihood to handle missing data yielded a final analytic sample of 606 women and 530 men ($N = 1136$). Participants were aged 18–60 years ($M = 39.1$, $SD = 12$). Sexual orientation was 90% heterosexual, 3% gay/lesbian, 6% bisexual, and 1% demi-, pan-, or asexual. The procedures for data collection and storage were approved by the Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research. Since the study did not involve health-related topics, it was exempt from ethical review by the Regional committees for medical and health research ethics.

Table 1
Research questions.

Study Objectives	Ranking
Research Question 1	Secondary
At the population level, is pickiness realistic or excessive?	
For each of the 16 mate-preference traits, do respondents' minimum standards align with the trait's expected distribution in the population?	
Does the average minimum standard across the 16 mate-preference traits align with what the population can be expected to provide?	
Do respondents' height standards align with the measured height distribution in the Norwegian adult population?	
Research Question 2	
Does pickiness predict relationship involvement (i.e., the following outcomes)?	
Objective Outcomes (variables)	
Years	Primary
Single	
In uncommitted relationships	
In committed relationships	
Number of	Secondary
Committed relationships	
Uncommitted relationships	
Sexual partners	
Subjective Outcomes (variables)	Secondary
Involuntary Uncommitted Relationships	
Reasons for Involuntary Singlehood	
Struggling to attract a partner	
Others are interested, but not those I'm interested in	
Interested in persons unwilling to commit	
Research Question 3	Exploratory
Can mate preferences be modeled using a bifactor framework?	
Does adding a global mate preferences factor improve model fit relative to a correlated-factors model?	
Which sub-factors of mate preferences remain after accounting for a global mate preferences factor?	

Research objectives of this study. Following APA's Journal Article Reporting Standards (Cooper, 2018), the objectives are structured as primary, secondary, and exploratory.

2.2. Measures

The full survey is provided in the supplementary materials, including participant information, informed consent form, complete item descriptions and wordings, and the order in which items were presented.

2.2.1. Predictor variables

2.2.1.1. Pickiness. Pickiness was assessed for 16 traits previously identified as desirable in a romantic partner (e.g., kind, intelligent, attractive body; Buss & Barnes, 1986; wording similar to Costello et al., 2024). For each trait, participants indicated the minimum level a partner could possess on a 0–10 scale. They were instructed to imagine that each trait follows a normal distribution in the population and that each scale point corresponds to a percentile label (e.g., top 50/100, bottom 8/100, top 3/100) representing the lowest percentile they would accept. Thus, selecting 6 out of 10 for facial attractiveness meant the partner must be at least more attractive than 68% of the population. Minimum and maximum acceptable height were recorded in centimeters on a 140–220 cm scale.

Note that the instructions referred only to minimum preferences for "a partner", not specifically a long-term partner. We deliberately chose this broader term, reasoning that asking participants to imagine a long-term partner might prime them to report criteria they would be unlikely to pursue in practice. Individuals tend to overestimate the importance of traits typically linked to long-term relationships (e.g., earning potential) and downplay those more salient in short-term contexts (e.g., physical attractiveness; Eastwick et al., 2025). Nevertheless, the wording still implied a more committed relationship, as confirmed by pilot testing.

2.2.2. Outcome variables

2.2.2.1. Years in relationship statuses. Participants were asked to estimate the total number of years and months they had spent in committed- and uncommitted relationships. Long-term committed relationships were described as those in which participants explicitly defined themselves as a couple. Uncommitted relationships were defined as those that persisted over time but in which participants had not explicitly decided that they were a couple (e.g., steady dating).

We calculated the length of singlehood by subtracting participants' time spent in committed and uncommitted relationships from their age. Although strictly redundant, including singlehood clarifies which relationship status is reduced by pickiness. For example, if pickiness increases singlehood, it may correspondingly reduce time spent in committed relationships, uncommitted relationships, or both. When

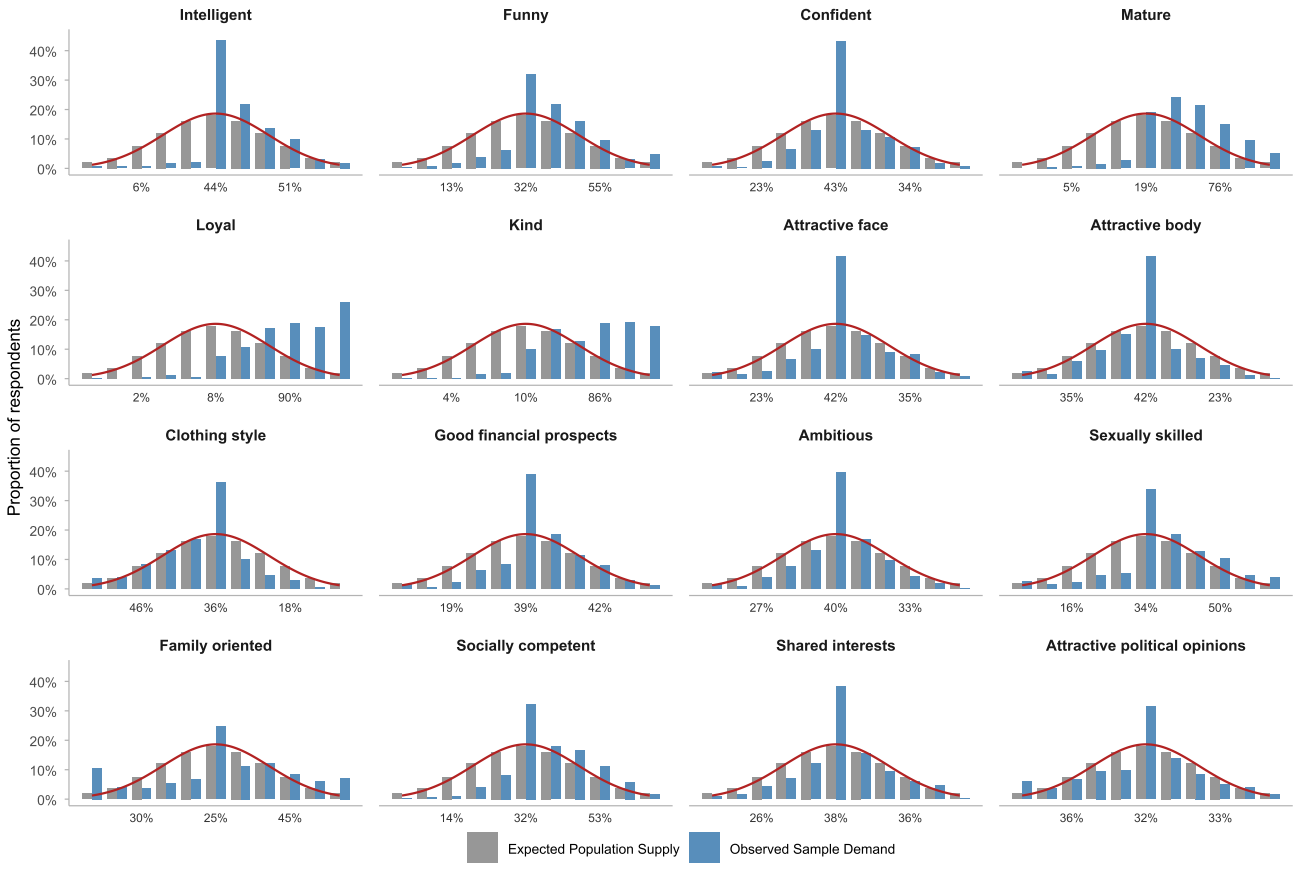


Fig. 1. Minimum mate standards for women.
Gray bars show the expected distribution of the trait in the population (and the distribution respondents were asked to imagine), whereas the blue bars show women's minimum requirements for the trait. The percentages beneath each plot display how many women had below-average requirements (0–4), average requirements (5), and above-average requirements (6–10).

subtracting years in uncommitted relationships from years in committed relationships, 3% of participants had less than 13 years as single. We increased the duration of singlehood for these participants to 13 years. This adjustment prevented perfect correlations among the three relationship-duration variables, also needed for the analysis to converge.

2.2.2.2. Number of relationships and sex partners. Participants reported the number of long-term relationships and uncommitted relationships on an integer scale ranging from 0 to "More than 10." They also reported their total number of sexual partners using a scale with a maximum response of "50 or more."

2.2.2.3. Involuntary uncommitted relationships. We developed three questions to measure participants' experiences of involuntary uncommitted relationships—that is, sexual relationships participants wished would progress to long-term partnerships, but which did not.

1. I've been in sexual relationships where I wanted us to become partners (or "something more"), but it never came to be.
2. I've been in sexual relationships where I wanted us to become partners (or "something more"), but they seemed to hold back.
3. I've gone to bed with persons I wanted to get to know better, but they did not appear interested in such.

While the first question does not specify why the relationship did not progress, the second and third questions indicate that the partner was responsible for the lack of progression. Participants gave their responses on a five-point scale ranging from 1 (Not at all) to 5 (Strongly so).

We also aimed to reduce the frequency of structural zeros (He et al., 2014). In this context, structural zeros refer, for example, to participants responding "Not at all" because they've never had a sexual encounter, whereas "random zeros" occur when participants respond "Not at all" because their sexual experiences did not match the described scenarios. Participants were therefore instructed to select "Not relevant"if they believed the described situations could not have applied to them. Eighteen participants chose this option. Responses to the three items were averaged into a scale ($\omega = 0.86$, $\alpha = 0.85$).

2.2.2.4. Reasons for involuntary singlehood. Involuntary singlehood was assessed by agreement with being single due to three different reasons: (1) "I struggle(d) to attract a partner." This single item represents a commonly reported reason for involuntary singlehood (Apostolou et al., 2019a) and demonstrates predictive validity, such as decreased well-being (Apostolou et al., 2019b). (2) "I am/was interested in persons who do/did not want to commit." This item assesses singlehood resulting from involvement in involuntary uncommitted relationships. (3) "Persons are/were interested in me, but those I am/was interested in were not interested in return." This item is intended to assess involuntary singlehood arising not from a lack of interest from others, but from a failure to calibrate one's standards to these attainable partners. Those who were currently single got the questions in present tense. Those who were currently partnered got the question in past tense, and were asked to think back to when they were single. Participants responded using a five-point scale from 1 (Not at all) to 5 (Strongly so). Each item was retained as a separate dependent variable.

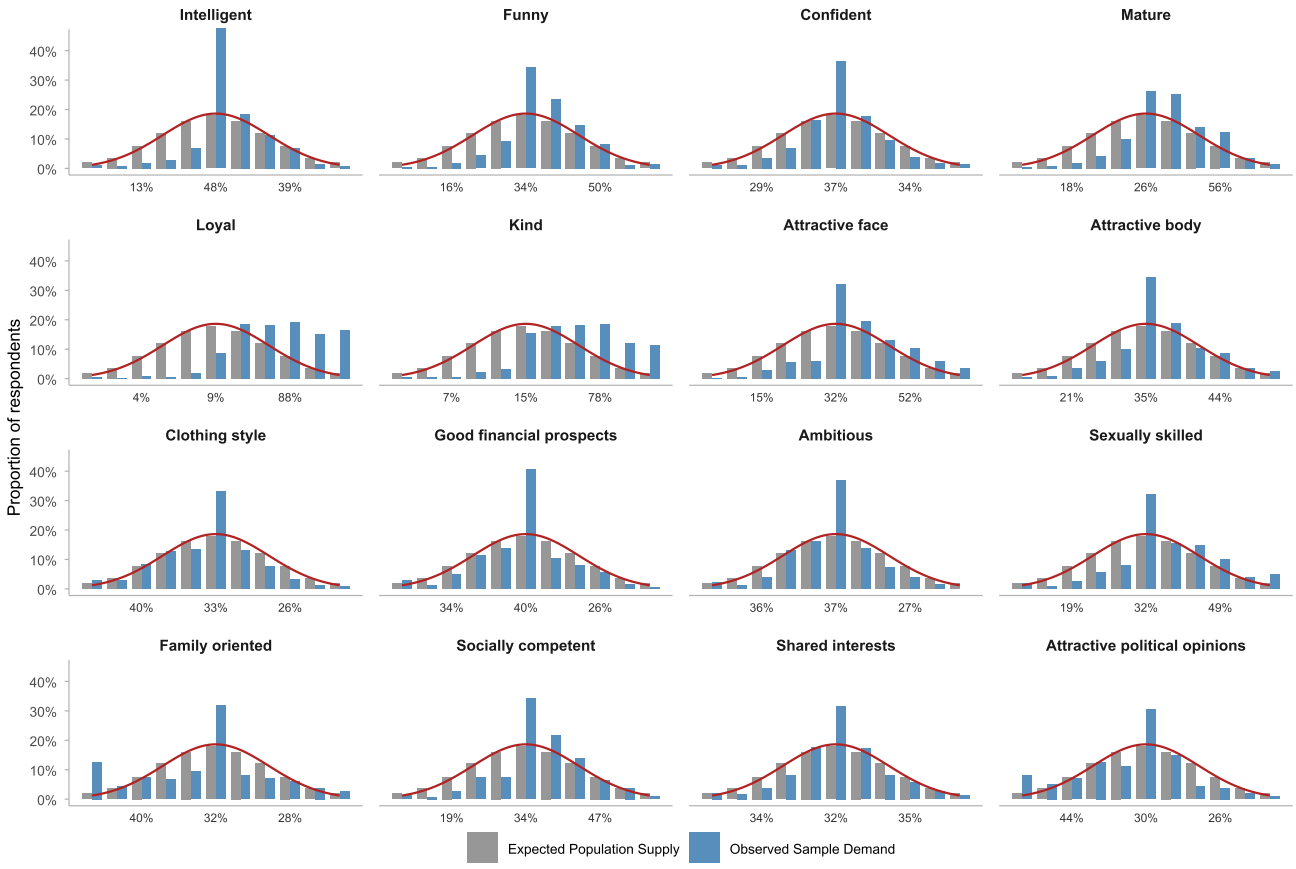


Fig. 2. Minimum mate standards for men.
Gray bars show the expected distribution of the trait in the population (and the distribution respondents were asked to imagine), whereas the blue bars show men's minimum requirements for the trait. The percentages beneath each plot display how many men had below-average requirements (0–4), average requirements (5), and above-average requirements (6–10).

2.2.3. Covariates

2.2.3.1. Self-perceived mate-value. We assessed self-perceived mate value for both short-term and long-term relationships using two single-item measures (Bendixen, 2014; Haselton, 2003). Participants rated their perceived desirability, relative to others of the same age and gender, as a partner for casual sexual relationships (e.g., a one-night stand) and long-term committed relationships (e.g., marriage). Responses were provided on a five-point scale ranging from 1 (Strongly below average) to 5 (Strongly above average).

2.2.3.2. Mate-seeking and mate-wanting. We constructed two items to assess mate-seeking and mate-wanting during singlehood. Mate-seeking was assessed with the item: "How actively are/were you trying to find a partner? (e.g., going on dates)." Mate-wanting was assessed with the item: "To what extent do/did you wish you had a partner?". Those who were currently single got the questions in present tense. Those who were currently partnered got the question in past tense and were asked to think back to when they were single. Participants rated their responses on five-point Likert scales.

2.3. Data analysis

Data analysis followed three stages. For research question 1, we examined how well each mate preference overlapped with the expected population distribution. A chi-square goodness-of-fit test (with Benjamini–Hochberg FDR correction) compared the sample to the expected distribution for each of the 16 traits. All differed significantly, but requiring as many as 11 response options to match a theorized null-distribution may not be feasible to expect. We instead compared the observed distribution to a uniform expectation in which 33% of respondents chose below average, 33% average, and 33% above average. The 16 mate standards were also averaged into a composite, also compared against an expected normal population distribution. See the supplement for details including tests of sex differences.

To assess whether height requirements aligned with the population distribution, we examined how well they overlapped with the distribution of adult height in Norway. Using NCD Risk Factor Collaboration data (NCD Risk Factor Collaboration, 2016), we averaged Norwegian birth cohorts 1963–1996, giving means of 179 cm for men and 166 cm for women. Standard deviations were taken from the Tromsø Study 1979–2016 (Arntsen et al., 2023, Table 1), 1960–69 cohort, at 6.80 cm for men and 6.24 cm for women. Height analysis was restricted to heterosexual participants.

We then examined whether minimum mate standards fit a bifactor structure (research question 3). Domain factors were first identified through exploratory factor analysis. Following Brown's (2015) procedure, we estimated a confirmatory bifactor model in two steps: domain factors were first fitted with their correlations freely estimated, after which all items were regressed simultaneously onto a general pickiness factor with all factor correlations constrained to zero. We then identified which domain factors remained in the presence of the global factor, removing those which no longer had significant item loadings. Modification indices were consulted to address misfit.

After establishing the factor structure of pickiness, we examined whether the pickiness factors predicted relationship involvement within a structural equation model. Relationship durations (years single, years committed, years uncommitted), number of past relationships, number

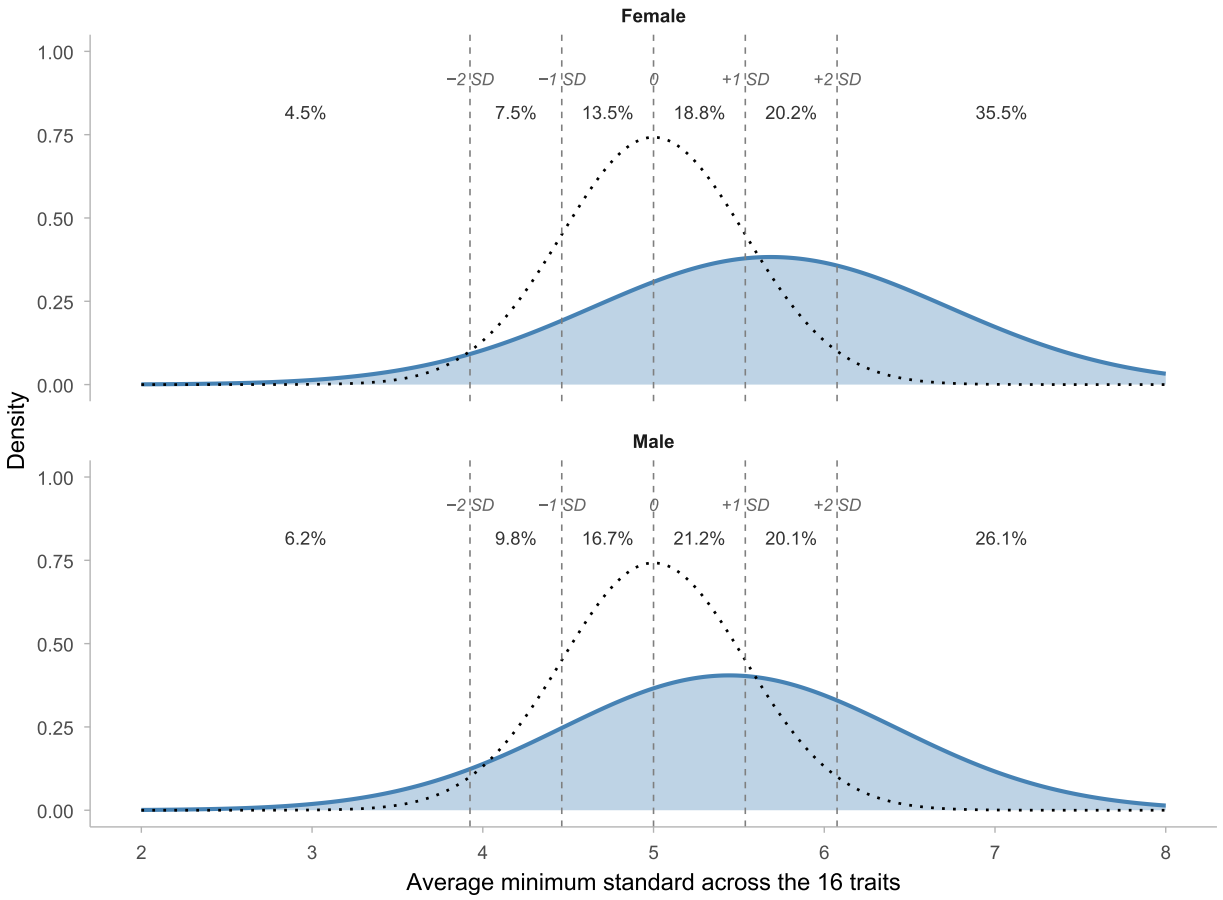


Fig. 3. Sample pickiness against expected population supply.
The blue area shows respondents' average minimum across the 16 traits, and the black dotted curve the expected population distribution. Dashed gray lines mark each standard deviation; percentages above show the proportion of each sex falling in each band.

of sexual partners, reasons for singlehood, and involuntary uncommitted relationships were regressed on the global and domain pickiness factors. The same dependent variables were also regressed on control variables age, long-term mate value, short-term mate value, mate wanting, and mate seeking. Correlations between the pickiness factors and the control variables, and residual covariances among the dependent variables, were freely estimated.

Analyses were conducted separately by sex in RStudio using lavaan (Rosseel, 2012). Full analyses and results are available in the supplementary materials, with code and data provided for reproducibility at OSF.[2]

3. Results

All trait requirements deviated significantly from the expected population distribution (see supplement), except attractive political opinions for women (36% below average, 32% average, 33% above average; $\chi^2 = 1.72$, $p = .42$, Cohen's $w = 0.05$), and confidence (29% below average, 37% average, 34% above average; $\chi^2 = 4.56$, $p = .10$, $w = 0.09$) and shared interests (34% below average, 32% average, 35% above average; $\chi^2 = 0.75$, $p = .69$, $w = 0.04$) for men. Greatest above average requirements appeared for loyalty and kindness. Only 2% of women and 4% of men accepted a below-average partner in loyalty; for kindness, 4% and 7%. On loyalty, 62% of women and 51% of men required their partner to score on the most upper end (8–10). For intelligence, fun, confidence, sexual skill, and social competence, only a minority of participants were willing to accept a partner below average — for example, 6% of women and 13% of men for intelligence. For these traits, however, requirements mostly clustered around average, such as 44% of women and 48% of men selected 5 out of 10 as their minimum standard for intelligence. For facial attractiveness, among women, 12% more required an above-average than a below-average partner (95% CI [6.0, 18.1]), as did 37% more among men (95% CI [31, 43]). For bodily attractiveness, the share of men requiring an above-average partner exceeded the share accepting a below-average partner by 24% (95% CI [17, 30]). For women, however, the share willing to accept a below-average partner on bodily attractiveness exceeded the share requiring an above-average partner by 12% (95% CI [−18, −6]). See Fig. 1 and Fig. 2 visual representations of distributions. See supplement for detailed test statistics.

When the sample's 16 mate standards were averaged, the resulting distribution was approximately normal (Fig. 3). Its mean, however, sat roughly one standard deviation above the expected population distribution (women: Cohen's $d = +1.28$; men: Cohen's $d = +0.82$). Furthermore, 36% of women and 26% of men set standards that would correspond to two standard deviations above average in the expected distribution. See supplement for details.

For partner height, women's stated median minima (Fig. 4, upper half) was 170 cm (IQR 168–175), 9 cm below the Norwegian male average of 179 cm ($SD = 6.8$). Around 7% of Norwegian men are below women's median criteria of 170 cm. Only 15% of women set a minimum at or above the male population mean ($\geq$ 180 cm), whereas only 5% required their partner to be at least 6 ft tall. Men's stated median minima (Fig. 4, lower half) was 155 cm (IQR 150–160), 11 cm below the female average of 166 cm ($SD = 6.2$). For maximum height, the maximum

[2] https://osf.io/mjczv/?view_only=1e07cc72c3694d3e86a0ef454ac946b5

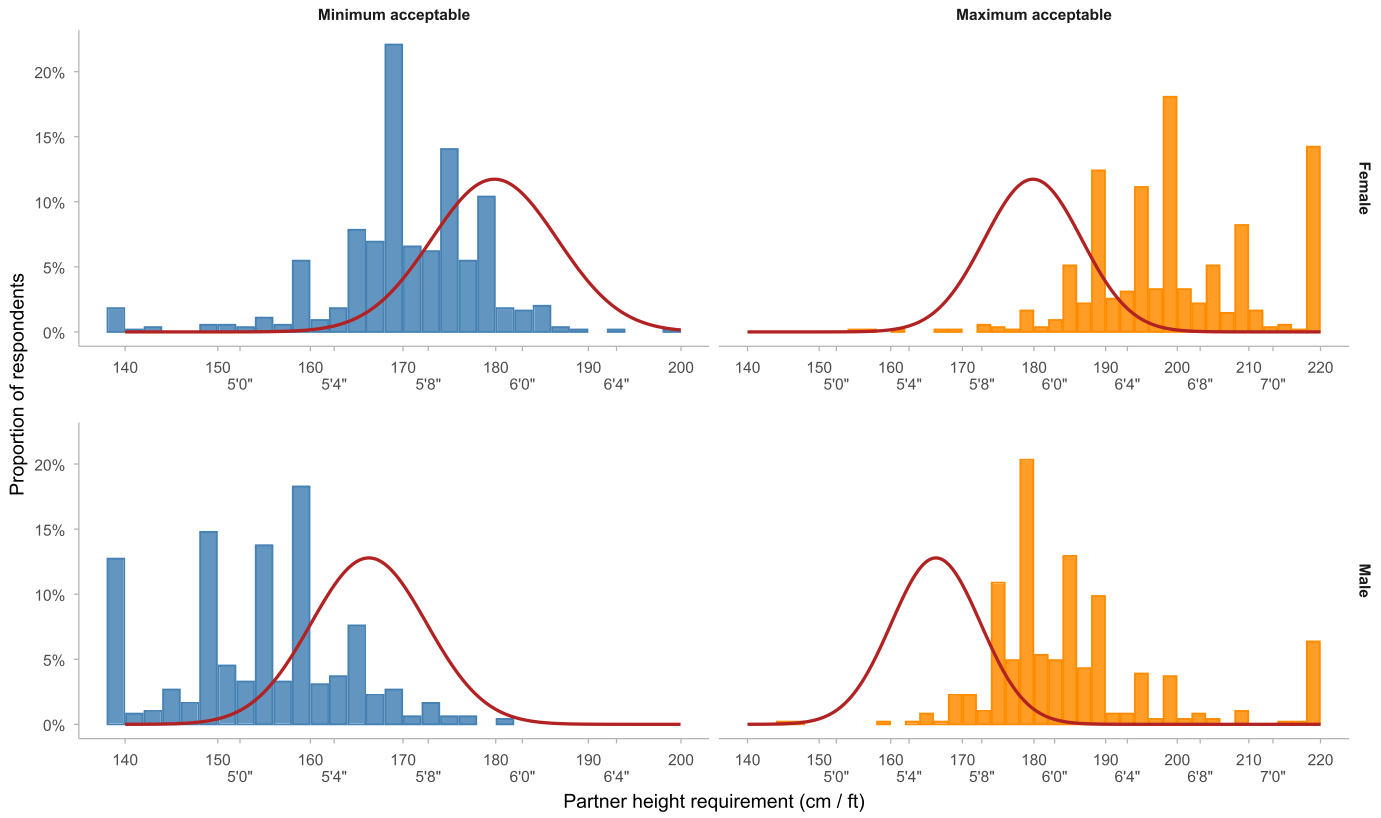


Fig. 4. Height requirements.
Women's height requirements are shown in the top row and men's in the bottom row. The left column shows minimum acceptable height, whereas the right column shows maximum acceptable height. Bin width: 2 cm. The solid curve shows the expected height distribution of Norwegian men (top) and women (bottom).

acceptable median height reported by women was 200 cm (IQR 191–209 cm). For men, the median maximum was 183 cm (IQR 179–190 cm).

3.1. Bifactor model of mate standards

Exploratory factor analysis (EFA) of the mate standards identified four factors seemingly similar to both sexes: Status-Industriousness, Dependable, Physical Attractiveness, and a broader Similarity-Intelligence factor. When these were modeled in a confirmatory factor analysis allowing the factors to correlate, fit was poor for women (χ^2 (98) = 360.76, RMSEA = 0.074, CFI = 0.899) and men (χ^2 (98) = 451.93, RMSEA = 0.083, CFI = 0.849). Introducing a global factor and setting factor correlations to zero improved the fit for women (χ^2 (119) = 283.75, RMSEA = 0.058, CFI = 0.927) and men (χ^2 (119) = 414.66, RMSEA = 0.068, CFI = 0.880). For both sexes, the Similarity-Intelligence factor was no longer significant and was thus removed. For women, three items from the Status-Industriousness factor were also removed due to non-significant loadings. Despite this, the factor remained broad, consisting of items Ambitious, Good Finances, Family-Oriented, and negatively loading on Funny, reflecting previously observed bipolarity in mate preferences (Shackelford et al., 2005). For men, the Status-Industriousness factor was no longer significant and was removed. The Dependable factor remained stable for both sexes, with items Loyal, Kind, and Mature. The Physical Attractiveness factor comprised Attractive Body, Attractive Face, and Style, plus Good at Sex for men and Minimum Height for women. All items loaded significantly onto the global factor except Maximum Height for women, which was therefore removed. We permitted three residual correlations for women and nine for men. The final bifactor models demonstrated good global fit for women (χ^2 (105) = 263.64, RMSEA = 0.050, CFI = 0.952) and men (χ^2 (117) = 266.12, RMSEA = 0.049, CFI = 0.940). The bifactor models are visually depicted in Fig. 5 (women) and Fig. 6 (men), with numerical details presented in Table A1 and Table A2 in the appendix. All EFA and CFA modeling steps are outlined in detailed in the supplement.

3.2. Effects of pickiness

We then transitioned from a confirmatory factor analysis to a structural equation model to examine the effects of pickiness factors. The dependent variables were regressed on the global- and domain specific pickiness factors, as well as on the control variables of age, self-perceived short-term mate-value, long-term mate-value, mate wanting, and mate seeking. The relations between the pickiness factors and the dependent variables were freely estimated. The model fit remained good for women (χ^2 (300) = 681.70, RMSEA = 0.046) and men (χ^2 (344) = 640.50, RMSEA = 0.040). As restricting the sample to heterosexuals did not yield significantly different results, we report the analyses for the full sample.

Considering objective outcomes, global pickiness for women did not predict years in committed relationships ($b = -0.18$, $p = .70$) or years single ($b = -0.27$, $p = .56$), but did predict more years spent in uncommitted relationships ($b = 0.40$, $p = .036$), as well as an increased number of uncommitted relationships ($b = 0.78$, $p < .001$) and sexual partners ($b = 0.70$, $p < .001$). For men, global pickiness predicted more years in committed relationships ($b = 1.58$, $p = .024$), an increased number of committed relationships ($b = 0.37$, $p = .043$), fewer years spent single ($b = -1.71$, $p = .015$), and a greater number of uncommitted relationships ($b = 0.80$, $p = .018$).

For men, pickiness for physical attractiveness predicted fewer years in committed relationships ($b = -0.41$, $p = .038$), fewer committed relationships ($b = -0.12$, $p = .011$), and more years single ($b = 0.41$, $p = .041$). For women, pickiness for dependable predicted fewer years ($b = -0.20$, $p = .042$) and fewer instances ($b = -0.26$, $p = .018$) of

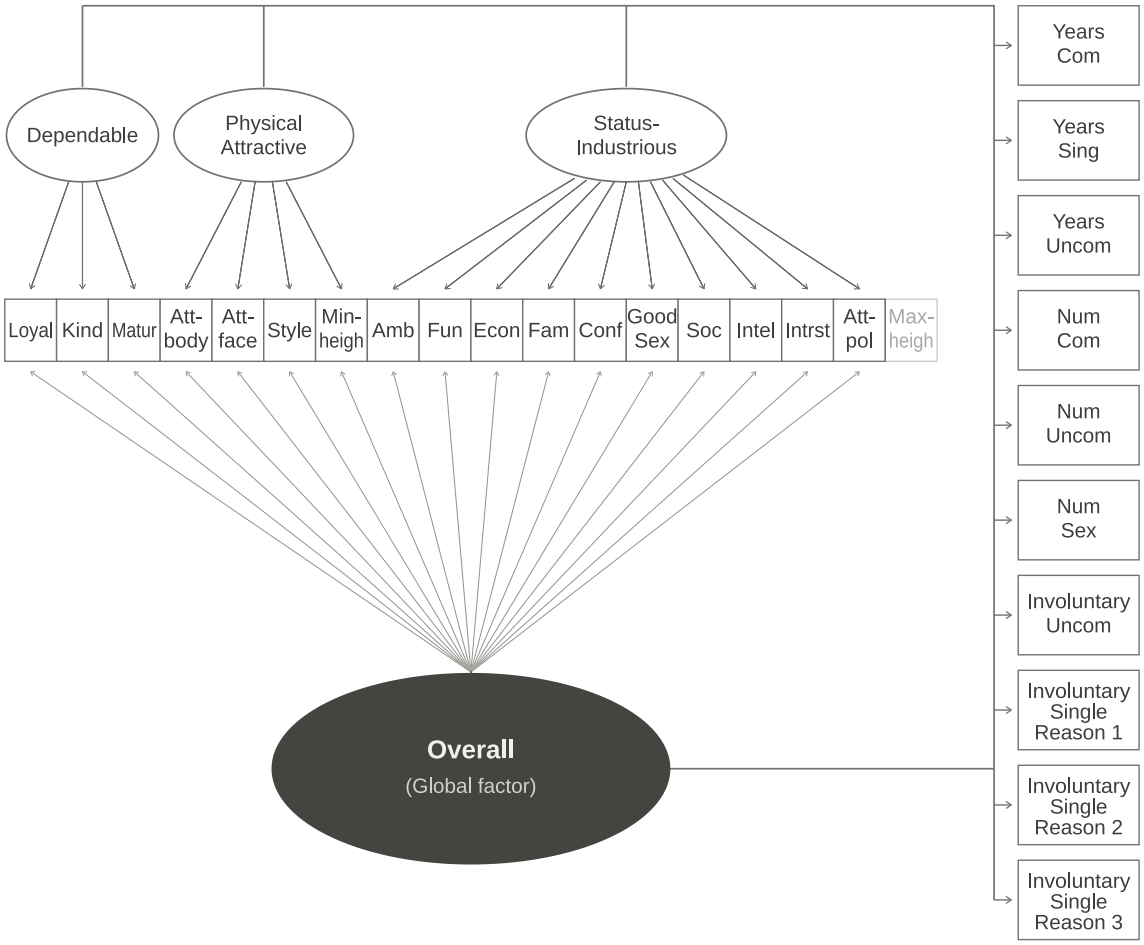


Fig. 5. Bifactor structural equation model for women.
Women's bifactor model comprised a global factor of overall pickiness, and domain factors Dependable, Physical Attractiveness and Status-Industriousness. All factors are set to predict the dependent variables, while controlling for age, mate-value, mate wanting, mate seeking. The control variables are omitted from the figure.

uncommitted relationships.

Global pickiness predicted increased reports of involvement in uncommitted relationships participants wished had progressed to commitment, for both women ($b = 0.29$, $p = .001$) and men ($b = 0.41$, $p = .001$). It also predicted women's reports of being single due to interest in partners unwilling to commit ($b = 0.18$, $p = .039$). Conversely, global pickiness predicted fewer reports of attraction difficulties for women ($b = -0.17$, $p = .038$) and men ($b = -0.33$, $p = .005$). Women's pickiness for dependability predicted fewer reports of involvement in uncommitted relationships they wish had progressed to commitment ($b = -0.15$, $p = .002$). Pickiness for Status-Industriousness also predicted less endorsement with the item "Persons are/were interested in me, but those I am/was interested in were not interested in return" ($b = -0.81$, $p = .024$).

See Table 2 for an overview of the effects of pickiness on relationships involvement. Correlations between objective and subjective measures of relationship involvement are shown in Table 3. Correlations between pickiness factors and control variables are shown in Table A3, and the effects of control variables on the dependent variables are presented in Table A4 (appendix).

4. Discussion

The primary objective of this investigation was to assess whether pickiness increases the number of years individuals spend single. We also attempted to assess whether mate standards are realistic at the level of the population, by examining whether the partner demands in a representative Norwegian sample reflected the desirability the population could be expected to supply.

The sample's pickiness was generally greater than the population could be expected to live up to. Across traits, individuals most often required their partner to be above average, followed by average, and rarely accepted a partner below average. When all traits were averaged together, few participants were willing to partner with someone below average, and around a quarter of individuals could be classified as requiring a partner two standard deviations greater in desirability than the expected population average. We then used participants' pickiness to predict their relationship involvement, expecting that those with greater pickiness would spend more years single, more years in uncommitted relationships, and fewer years in committed relationships. The effects of pickiness were however mixed, with greater pickiness both increasing and decreasing relationship involvement.

For men, greater pickiness for physical attractiveness predicted more years single, fewer years in committed relationships, and fewer committed relationships overall. Furthermore, at the observed-variable level, 85% and 80% of men required their partner to be at least average or above average in facial and bodily attractiveness, respectively. As such, most men reported being unwilling to partner with someone below average in physical attractiveness. These findings may be interpreted as men's expectations for physical attractiveness being excessive, thereby resulting in increased singlehood. The effect sizes were, however, small, with years single increasing by around half a year per increase in men's requirements for physical attractiveness.

Furthermore, men's overall pickiness decreased their singlehood and

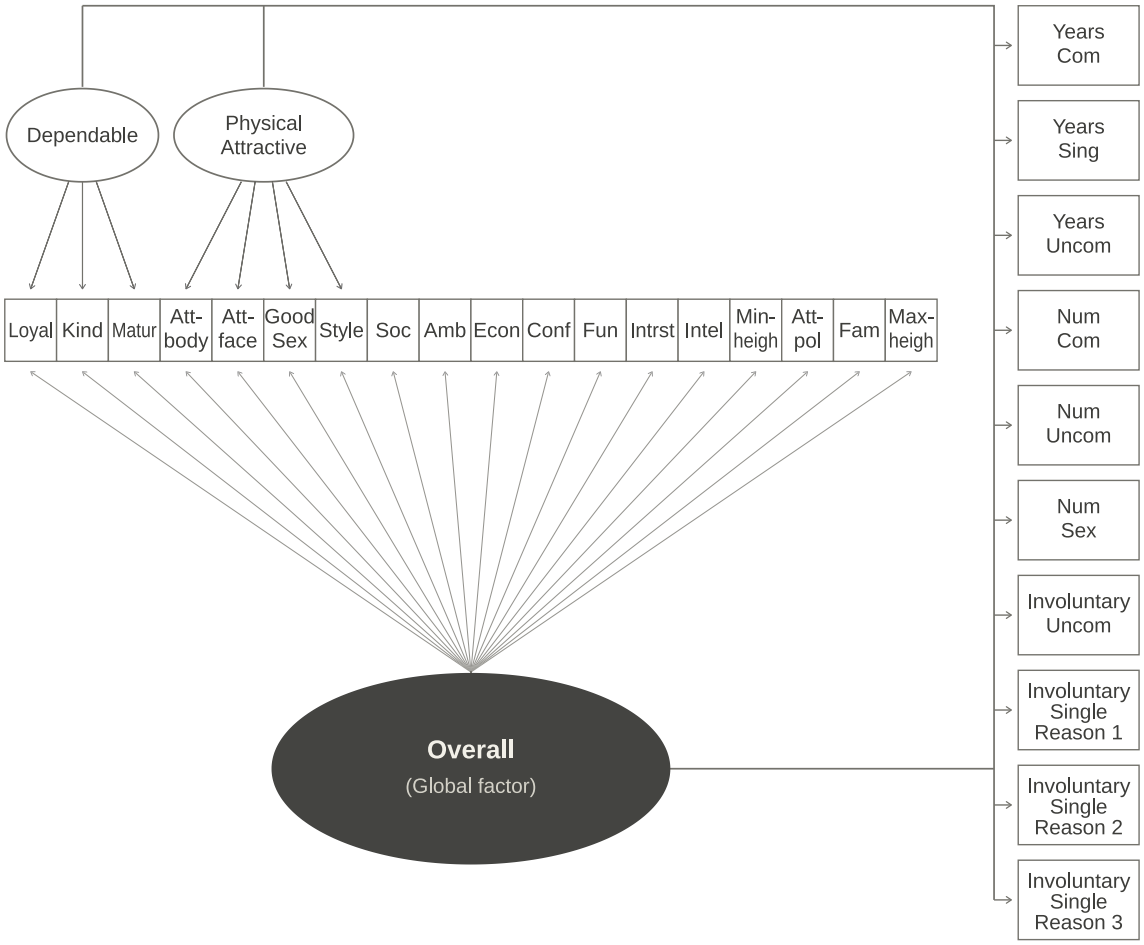


Fig. 6. Bifactor Structural Equation Model for Men.
Men's bifactor model comprised a global factor of overall pickiness, and domain factors Dependable and Physical Attractiveness. All factors are set to predict the dependent variables, while controlling for age, mate-value, mate wanting, mate seeking. The control variables are omitted from the figure.

increased their involvement in committed relationships. Each increase in men's overall pickiness was associated with spending around one and a half years less as single and one and a half years more in committed relationships. This is unexpected, as—while holding mate value constant—greater pickiness should make it harder to acquire a partner by reducing the number of eligible mates with increased competition for those mates. One possibility is that once the variance in physical attractiveness is extracted from men's overall choosiness (the domain men seemingly compete most intensely for) the remaining variance reflects standards that orient men toward traits reflecting suitability for long-term partnership. A separate possibility is that a lack of mate standards signals indiscriminateness or neediness, which is itself expected to be unattractive (see for example effects of men's attachment anxiety on speed dating interest McClure et al., 2010). Men who hold high overall standards may signal greater selectivity, making them more appealing as long-term partners and thereby increasing their opportunity to enter long-term relationships.

For women, contrary to expectations, pickiness was not associated with increases in singlehood or with decreases in committed relationships. This is particularly notable for physical attractiveness, which researchers have emphasized may be a leading contributor to women's singlehood (Larsen & Kennair, 2025). At the observed-variable level women's standards for physical attractiveness also did not appear excessive, sometimes falling below the expected population average. For bodily attractiveness, more women were willing to partner with someone below average (35%) than required an above-average partner (23%). Furthermore, women's minimum height requirements averaged 170 cm (5′7″), 10 cm (4 inches) below the Norwegian male average of 180 cm (5′11″). Around 93% of Norwegian men would meet women's minimum height standards of 170 cm, and only 5% of women had the "infamous" requirement that their partner be at least 6 ft tall. Thus, women's reported standards for physical appearance seem realistic, which may explain why their pickiness for physical attractiveness did not extend their singlehood or involvement in uncommitted relationships.

Women's overall pickiness did, however, consistently predict their involvement in uncommitted relationships. Those with greater overall pickiness reported more years in uncommitted relationships, a greater number of uncommitted relationships, and more sexual partners. Women also appeared to experience the uncommitted nature of these relationships as unwanted: years in uncommitted relationships, number of uncommitted relationships, and number of sexual partners all correlated with reports of having been in uncommitted relationships they wished had become committed, and of being single due to interest in partners unwilling to commit. Moreover, the greater women's overall pickiness, the more they reported both having been in uncommitted relationships they wished had become committed and being single due to interest in partners unwilling to commit. The effects of women's overall pickiness on their involvement in uncommitted relationships were therefore particularly consistent, as pickiness related similarly to objective and subjective outcomes, and these outcomes themselves converged. Furthermore, women's overall pickiness greatly exceeded what the population could be expected to supply, with 36% of women indicating that they require a partner two standard deviations greater in

Table 2
Effects of pickiness on relationship involvement.

Predictors	Time in Relationship Statuses			No. Relationships			Reasons for Involuntary Singlehood			Involuntary Uncommittedness
	Committed	Uncommitted	Single	Committed	Uncommitted	Sex Partners	1. Attraction struggles	2. Interested in those not wanting to commit	3. Not interested in those interested	
Overall Pickiness	−0.18 / 1.58*	0.40* / 0.07	−0.27 / −1.71*	0.22 / 0.37*	0.78*** / 0.77*	0.70** / 0.30	−0.17* / −0.32**	0.18* / 0.04	0.03 / 0.05	0.29** / 0.41**
Dependable	−0.14 / 0.33	−0.20* / −0.17	0.29 / −0.17	−0.00 / −0.00	−0.26* / −0.03	0.13 / 0.12	−0.01 / −0.04	−0.03 / −0.10	−0.05 / −0.04	−0.15** / −0.07
Physical Attractiveness	0.26 / −0.41*	−0.15 / 0.02	−0.11 / 0.41*	−0.54 / −0.12*	−0.16 / −0.01	−0.14 / 0.02	−0.03 / 0.03	−0.00 / −0.03	−0.02 / −0.02	−0.08 / 0.02
Status-Industriousness	6.25 / NA	−0.61 / NA	−5.42 / NA	−0.34 / NA	−1.24 / NA	− 1.16 / NA	0.61 / NA	−0.29 / NA	−0.81* / NA	−0.56 / NA

Path coefficients from the structural equation model. Left of the slash represents women, right of the slash, represents men. Large estimates for Status-Industriousness indicate unstable estimates. See supplement for all test statistics.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$.

desirability than the expected population average. Taken together, this investigation does lend some support to the notion that women's overall partner requirements may be excessive, making them susceptible to date desirable men whose long-term standards they fall short of (i.e., women themselves not living up to the men's mate standards), thereby compounding women's involvement in uncommitted sexual relationships. However, as mentioned, women's pickiness did not increase the number of years they spent single.

Women's pickiness for dependability was negatively related to years spent in uncommitted relationships, the number of uncommitted relationships, and subjective reports of involvement in relationships they wished had progressed to commitment. Perhaps women's heightened standards for dependability orient them away from partners inclined toward deception, or prompt them to terminate uncommitted relationships sooner, as a lack of commitment may itself signal lack of dependability. This interpretation departs from the notion that the goal of mate-standard adjustment is to lower one's standards to a level reflective of what one can attain, and instead suggests that some standards may remain adaptive to maintain at high levels regardless of assortation.

4.1. *Is there evidence of mismatch in mate-standard adaptations?*

Insofar as the current findings bear on whether adaptations show inefficacies in mate-standard adjustment (e.g., environmental mismatch), the evidence is mixed. The finding that pickiness for physical attractiveness increased singlehood among men need not reflect that men struggle to set realistic standards. On the contrary, it may be adaptive for men to trade half a year of additional singlehood per increase in pickiness for attractiveness in exchange for acquiring a mate of greater mate value. The finding that women self-report that they continue to remain single due to pursuit of partners unwilling to commit may indicate that women currently struggle to differentiate which standards they can set for long-term versus short-term partners, and adjust their pickiness following unsuccessful courtship. Alternatively, following Goetz and colleagues' (2019) argument, it may historically have been viable for women to court men whose short-term standards they initially only met, since they could exert pressure on these men to commit (e.g., through pregnancy or parental pressure). Since women now have less leverage to exert commitment pressure, such a bait-and-switch strategy may be less effective at converting short-term relationships into long-term ones. However, women's standards did not increase the actual duration of their singlehood. As such, women's heightened pickiness may be functional—allowing them to derive (indirect) genetic benefits through short-term mating—without lowering the extent of their long-term mating. In sum, the findings are inconclusive in whether individuals are struggling to set realistic standards in terms of those standards lowering reproductive success.

4.2. *Mate standard domains—New insights*

A secondary aim of this investigation was to examine whether mate preferences could be effectively modeled using a bifactor structure. Doing so would help identify the "true" sub-domains of mate preferences while controlling for a general mate preferences factor. When accounting for a global mate-preference factor (overall pickiness), traits related to similarity and intelligence merged into the global factor. Women's specific mate-preference domains thus included Dependable, Physical Attractiveness, and Status-Industriousness, while men retained only Dependable and Physical Attractiveness. This can be interpreted as women being uniquely attentive to a partner's Status-Industriousness, beyond a partner's overall mate quality. This aligns with Sexual Strategies Theory, which predicts that women will place greater emphasis on a partner's earning potential (Buss & Schmitt, 1993). Both sexes remained uniquely attentive to dependability and physical attractiveness beyond that of overall mate standards. This further aligns with Sexual Strategies

Table 3
Correlations Between Relationship Involvement and Measures of Involuntariness.

Rel. Involvement	Reasons (Involuntary) Single			Involuntary Uncommittedness
	1. Attraction struggles	2. Interested in those not wanting to commit	3. Not interested in those interested	
Time in Relationships				
Committed	−.29*** / –0.27***	−.12** / −.08	−.15*** / –.16***	−.10* / –.10*
Uncommitted	–.08 / –.18***	.11* / .04	.07 / .10*	.28*** / .21***
Single	.36*** / .21***	.00 / −.04	.09** / .10*	.09* / .12**
No. Relationships				
Committed	−.21*** / –.15***	.02 / .04	−.10* / .07	.18*** / .16***
Uncommitted	−.15*** / –.29***	.24*** / .13**	.12** / .15***	.36*** / .34***
Sex Partners	−.14*** / –.32***	.20*** / .10*	.06 / .13**	.37*** / .34***

These correlations are not from the structural equation model; they are regular (zero-order) Pearson's correlations. Left of the slash represents women, right of the slash represents men.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$.

Theory, which suggests that physical attractiveness signals genetic quality, while dependability signals lower abandonment risk for women and increased parental certainty for men.

4.3. Limitations and future research

This investigation has several limitations, including lack of longitudinal data. We cannot confirm whether pickiness has remained stable over participants' lifetimes. Although existing research indicates that mate preferences show stability similar to personality (Bredow & Hames, 2019), research on how mate preferences may change across the lifespan is lacking. Relationship experiences may also be expected to affect mate standards. For example, rather than women's overall pickiness leading them to become involved in uncommitted relationships, women's involvement in uncommitted relationships may itself heighten their mate preferences—potentially expecting higher standards to orient them toward partners less inclined to avoid commitment. Future research should longitudinally examine the reciprocal cross-lagged effects between pickiness and relationship involvement.

Our emphasis on years in long-term relationships as a proxy for mating success overlooks *adaptive* singlehood. Mate standards increasing singlehood may reflect individuals choosing to remain single in order to acquire somatic resources (e.g., Wang et al., 2023) — subsequently enabling them to attract mates meeting such standards. Conversely, increased relationship involvement resulting from lower pickiness may itself be maladaptive, for example if one's partner is abusive. Future investigators should examine mate standards in relation to variables reflective of adaptive forms of singlehood.

Self-reported mate preferences have been criticized for lacking predictive validity (Eastwick & Finkel, 2008), and one study found that whereas revealed pickiness predicted fewer sexual relationships, self-reported pickiness did not (Close et al., 2025). Others, however, have found that mate preferences do predict mate choice (Li et al., 2013), and that among the several ways of measuring mate preferences, minimum mate standards may be more consequential for mate choice (Csajbók et al., 2022). Furthermore, studies contrasting revealed and self-reported preferences can be criticized for weak measurement of the self-reported preferences (e.g., whether a trait is "essential," yes/no [Close et al., 2025]). The present investigation measured 16 traits using 0–10 scales, on which participants indicated the minimum acceptable population percentile, as well as minimum and maximum acceptable height. This more stringent measurement of self-reported mate standards may partly offset individuals' limited insight into their own mating psychology. Nevertheless, it remains a considerable limitation that individuals may misjudge their actual standards, and we advise future investigators to examine revealed pickiness against the dependent variables used in this study.

Furthermore, asking participants for the minimum level they will accept along a normal distribution presupposes that the trait is normally distributed. This is reasonable for traits like intelligence and physical attractiveness: these are normally distributed, and individuals have sufficient everyday exposure to form a mental representation against which to set a cutoff. Other mate preferences are unlikely to be normally distributed. For example, it is unlikely that most people are only "moderately" loyal to their partner (plausibly, most are highly loyal). Instructing participants to set a minimum along a distribution that does not reflect a trait's actual distribution is a threat to ecological validity. Men and women also differ in how their respective populations are distributed on a given trait. For facial attractiveness, the central tendency for men is lower than that for women (i.e., male faces are less attractive), while women show greater dispersion (Wassiliwizky et al., 2026). Men's and women's pickiness cutpoints may therefore not be entirely comparable, since the distributions against which they are set differ.

The bifactor model had several limitations, including a lack of simple structure of domain factors, and non-invariance across sexes. Given that our items were diverse in content, and that we may not have had enough items from each expected domain, the current solution may underestimate the number of mate preference factors. Researchers are advised to use more comprehensive item sets (e.g., Csajbók & Berkics, 2017; Conroy-Beam et al., 2022, supplement). A bifactor model may also be examined against the three G's: Good Genes, Good Providers, and Good Fathers/Mothers (Chang et al., 2017; Lu et al., 2015). Potentially, by including more items directly relating to parental provision, the current Status-Industriousness factor may split into Good Providers and Good Fathers factors, while still controlling for a general mate preferences factor. See the supplement for a more detailed discussion of the bifactor model.

4.4. Generalizability

Norway is religiously secular and ranks among the highest countries in gender equality (World Economic Forum, 2024), financial equality (World Bank, 2024), and social progressiveness (Social Progress Imperative, 2025). Such ecological factors may influence mate preferences (Burtăverde & Ene, 2021). Yet, sex differences in mate preferences are roughly similar in Norway and the United States (Kennair et al., 2023), although sex differences in preferences for resources tend to be smaller (Mehmetoglu et al., 2024). Prior research has shown that status is relatively unimportant in predicting mate choice among college students, likely due to the limited variability in college students' status (Csajbók et al., 2022). Given Norway's high level of financial equality, the influence of status on mate choice in our sample may differ from cultures with greater financial inequality. The findings are also primarily applicable to cultures where relationships usually begin as uncommitted (courtship), thus limiting generalizability to contexts with practices like arranged marriages.

5. Conclusion

The partner requirements of singles generally exceeded the desirability the population could be expected to supply, indicating that singles have unrealistic partner expectations. Pickiness also explained the number of years spent single, in uncommitted relationships, and in committed relationships—with pickiness for physical attractiveness increasing men's years single, and women's overall pickiness increasing their years in uncommitted relationships. The effects of pickiness were, however, mixed and inconsistent. Pickiness did not increase the number of years women spent single, whereas overall pickiness unexpectedly increased men's years in committed relationships. In sum, while singles' stated partner requirements appear excessive, the evidence for whether these requirements contribute to increases in singlehood remains mixed.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Marius Stavang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Mons Bendixen:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Thomas H. Kleppestø:** Writing – review & editing, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Leif Edward Ottesen Kennair:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Investigation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interests

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests: Marius Stavang reports financial support was provided by Norwegian Broadcasting Corporation. Marius Stavang reports a relationship with Norwegian Broadcasting Corporation that includes: consulting or advisory. The data were funded and collected in collaboration with the Norwegian Broadcasting Corporation (NRK) for the documentary-reality series "Singelgåten," which followed individuals who had long been single, desired romantic relationships, but experienced difficulties becoming partnered. The series documented their journey over several months, connecting them with professionals specializing in singlehood. One component involved guiding participants in assessing their level of pickiness. The first author had contestants rate themselves on the pickiness items, then calculated their percentile rankings relative to the study's representative Norwegian sample. During one episode, the first author presented contestants with their scores, enabling them to gauge their choosiness relative to others and reflect on how their choosiness might be a contributing factor to their singlehood. It could then be argued that our involvement in the series presents a conflict of interest, as we might have felt pressured to align our findings with the narrative portrayed in the episodes. However, we maintain that our empirical results remain largely independent of the TV-series. Our objective during filming was not to statistically explain contestants' singlehood through pickiness scores, but to use these scores for qualitative reflection. Thus, even if the study had found no significant effects, using percentile scores to aid participants in their introspections would remain valid. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. Appendix

Table A1
Women's bifactor model of minimum mate standards (Pickiness).

Variable	Overall (Global)	Dependable	Physical Attractiveness	Status-Industriousness			R2
Loyal	0.51	0.77					0.85
Kind	0.46	0.62					0.60
Mature	0.55	0.40					0.46
Attractive body	0.57		0.77				0.92
Attractive face	0.57		0.53				0.60
Clothing style	0.56		0.33				0.43
Minimum height	0.36		0.15				0.15
Ambitious	0.59			0.37			0.48
Funny	0.65			−0.38			0.57
Good finances or financial prospects	0.61			0.34			0.49
Family oriented	0.31			0.19			0.13
Confident	0.62						0.39
Sexually skilled	0.62						0.38
Socially competent	0.59						0.35
Intelligent	0.47						0.22
Shared interests	0.38						0.13
Attractive political opinions	0.27						0.07
Model	χ^2	df	RMSEA	90% CI	SRMR	CFI	TLI
Correlated factors model	420.30	98	0.074	0.067–0.081	0.053	0.899	0.876
Bifactor Model	360.76	119	0.058	0.051–0.065	0.047	0.927	0.906
Bifactor model with residual correlations	263.64	105	0.050	0.042–0.057	0.041	0.952	0.937

Table A2
Men's bifactor model of minimum mate standards (Pickiness).

Variable		Overall (Global)	Dependable		Physical Attractiveness	R2	
Loyal		0.40	0.71			0.66	
Kind		0.47	0.67			0.67	
Mature		0.46	0.37			0.35	
Attractive body		0.46			1.10 [a]	> 1 [a]	
Attractive face		0.54			0.45	0.50	
Sexually skilled		0.60			0.17	0.39	
Clothing style		0.58			0.12	0.35	
Socially competent		0.64				0.41	
Ambitious		0.59				0.35	
Good finances or financial prospects		0.56				0.31	
Confident		0.51				0.26	
Funny		0.44				0.20	
Shared interests		0.39				0.15	
Intelligent		0.35				0.13	
Minimum height		0.29				0.09	
Attractive political opinions		0.26				0.07	
Family oriented		0.23				0.05	
Maximum height		−0.17				0.03	
Model	χ^2	df	RMSEA	90% CI	SRMR	CFI	TLI
Correlated factors model	451.93	98	0.083	0.075–0.090	0.067	0.849	0.815
Bifactor Model	414.66	119	0.068	0.061–0.076	0.057	0.880	0.846
Bifactor model with residual correlations	290.63	119	0.052	0.045–0.060	0.051	0.930	0.911

[a] The factor solution produced a Heywood case, as indicated by a factor loading and corresponding R2 exceeding one.

Table A3
Correlations between control variables and pickiness factors.

Covariates	Domains of Pickiness			
	Men and Women			Women
	Overall (Global) Pickiness	Dependable	Physical Attractiveness	Status-Industiousness
Mate value long-term	.22*** / .13*	.02 / .03	.09 / .00	.14 / NA
Mate value short-term	.27*** / .14*	−.04 / −.15**	.11* / .04	−.04 / NA
Mate wanting	−.02 / −.09	.03 / .12*	.04 / −.03	.29*** / NA
Mate seeking	.03 / .09	− .03 / .03	−.01 / −.05	.19* / NA
Age of participant	.07 / .15**	−.13** / −.24***	.07 / −.01	−.22* / NA

Correlations from the structural equation model. Left of slash represents women, right of slash represents men.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$.

Table A4
Effects of control variables on dependent variables.

Covariates	Time in Relationship Statuses			No. Relationships			Reasons for Involuntary Singlehood			Involuntary Uncommitttedness
	Committed	Uncommitted	Single	Committed	Uncommitted	Sex Partners	1. Attraction struggles	2. Interested in those not wanting to commit	3. Not interested in those interested	
Mate value long-term	0.84* / 1.15***	−0.32* / −0.29	−0.57 / −0.91**	0.09 / 0.06	−0.09 / −0.35*	−0.03 / −0.19	−0.18*** / −0.17**	−0.08 / −0.24***	0.03 / −0.10	−0.08 / −0.07
Mate value short-term	−0.20 / 0.32	0.14 / 0.56***	0.10 / −0.76**	0.01 / 0.17*	0.24* / 0.74***	0.40*** / 0.66***	−0.17** / −0.21***	0.04 / 0.17***	0.02 / 0.08	0.08 / 0.08
Mate wanting	−0.79 / −0.08	0.02 / −0.25	0.71 / 0.25	−0.17* / −0.20*	−0.13 / −0.70***	−0.06 / −0.71***	0.32*** / 0.38***	0.28*** / 0.15**	0.28*** / 0.08	0.21*** / 0.05
Mate seeking	0.59 / 0.34	0.07 / −0.01	−0.65* / −0.36	0.16* / 0.29***	0.41** / 0.55***	0.39** / 0.52***	0.01 / −0.04	0.20*** / 0.11*	0.07 / 0.15**	0.10 / 0.11*
Age of participant	0.78*** / 0.69***	0.02 / 0.05***	0.20*** / 0.25***	0.06*** / 0.04***	0.01 / 0.05***	0.05*** / 0.06***	−0.01 / −0.01**	−0.01** / −0.01*	−0.02** / −0.01	−0.01 / −0.00

Effects from the structural equation model. Left of slash represents women, right of slash represents men.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$.

Appendix B. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2026.106956.

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